

WORLD IN AN EMBRACE

The World in an Embrace - *India Today's* special offline issue was released by Mata Amritanandamayi on her 56th birthday at a glittering function held at Amrita Viswa Vidyapeetham (AVV) campus at Amritapuri in Kollam on 27 September 2009. The 120-page bilingual (English and Malayalam) omnibus issue covers the entire range of services and activities of the Mata Amritanandamayi Matt (MAM) in and out of the country and also contains articles by her various celebrity disciples besides an in-depth and exclusive interview with her. The issue is enriched by about 100 special photographs of Mata and the activities of the MAM. The *India Today* special volume is available in all major metros and state capital book stalls. Mata's 56th birthday celebrations held at the MAM Ashram and the adjacent AVV campus on September 26 and 27 was attended by lakhs of her devotees who have come from various parts of the world. Keenly attended by the common folk as well as the high and mighty the highlight of the first day of celebrations was the expansion of the Vidyamritham Educational scholarship to 2000 more children. With this the beneficiaries of the scholarship being distributed by MAM to children from impoverished families from various parts of India and abroad too has reached 32000. Vidyamritham was launched in 2007 in order to help the children of farmers struggling against indebtedness, drought, crop failure etc. The latest batch of beneficiaries coming from Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Karnataka and Kerala also has children who have lost parents to suicide etc.

The objective of Vidyamritham is to support 100,000 poor children until they complete their education said Swami Amrithaswaroopananda, Vice Chairman, MAM. The scholarships were distributed by Vayalar Ravi, Union Minister for Overseas Indian Affairs. The kindness of Amma is overwhelming said Ravi. The function Vidyamritha Sangamam 2009- was inaugurated by R S Gavai, Governor of Kerala. Both the Governor and his wife paid obeisance to Mata at the function. Mohanlal, Malayalam cinema's superstar too graced the function and spoke on how during his college days he had travelled from Trivandrum to come and meet Mata. Lal later sat with the Mata for an interaction with the thousands of students who have turned up for Mata's birthday.

The second day - Matas birthday - witnessed a mammoth gathering at the Ashram and the AVV lakhs of persons turned up to seek her blessings. The human sea at the Ashram consisted of citizens from various countries, men and women, old and young, rich and poor, elite and ordinary. Everyone who thronged the Ashram on her birthday had just one wish - to meet Mata. And as is her wont, Mata did not discriminate or disappoint anyone and blessed everyone with her famed and soothing embrace.

On her birthday Mata presented the Amritakeerthi Puraskar 2009 to Prof. K V Dev for his contributions to the philosophical literature. Other highlights of the celebration was an anti-alcohol pledge undertaken by 56 persons and the mass marriage of 56 couples from poor families for which all the expenses were borne by the MAM. ●



Mata Amritanandamayi